THE PINK LEMON



Why Losing Isn't Always What It Looks Like

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CHAPTER ONE

Not One

I loved baseball before I knew much about winning or losing. I grew up in Cleveland in the 1990s, which was a good time to fall in love with the game. The Indians had players like Kenny Lofton, Albert Belle, and Omar Vizquel. A city that had waited years for a championship could talk itself into believing this was finally the team. They made the World Series twice that decade and lost both times. As a kid, I couldn't explain why being so close made it hurt more.

I watched games, played pickup ball with friends, and hit in batting cages. On library trips with my dad, I grabbed baseball books. *Nolan Ryan's Pitcher's Bible* is one I remember. I wanted to know why one person could throw harder and another could hit better. What did practice actually change? I just wanted to know how people got good.

My dad had a simple answer for what to do when you weren't good enough yet. You kept going. You didn't sit around feeling sorry for yourself. You figured out what to do and tried again. Nobody was going to climb inside your life and fix it for you. I still believe that.

Some losses really are that simple. You were not ready, or someone worked harder, or someone had a skill you did not. Maybe you got distracted, let fear take over, or assumed that wanting something would be enough. If that is what happened, I would rather know. I don't want somebody to protect my feelings with a story that isn't

true. Talking about failure should not excuse us from looking honestly at our part.

Baseball taught me some of that. It also taught me that it wasn't the whole story. When I tried out for my high school team in eleventh grade, I felt ready. It was at least the kind of ready I understood then.

Then I got around other kids who wanted the same spot. Some had better gear. Some had travel teams, coaches, and practice that pickup games couldn't fully replace. That didn't mean they didn't work, because they did. It also didn't mean I had done nothing. We had reached the same tryout by different roads. That may have been the first time I saw how many people can care deeply about the same chance. The roster had only so many places. Wanting a spot was not going to make my preparation equal to theirs.

Business works the same way, because many people want the same customer. Wanting something badly can feel special when you are alone with that wish. Then you walk into a room full of people who want it just as badly. You realize that wanting it is only the starting point. Preparation, access, and the small details begin to matter.

I made the team, and that matters, because for years I judged the story by how it ended. The ending disappointed me, so I treated the whole experience as a disappointment. Then I got injured. I never really got to see what my full potential in baseball might have been. That's the story, and I don't need to make it bigger than it was. But I was disappointed. Baseball had filled so much of my imagination that I had to find new things to dream about.

I grieved it, and then I moved on. What I didn't understand yet was why this loss felt different. If another kid struck me out, that told me something. He might have had a better pitch, or my timing might have been off. An injury didn't tell me anything like that. I had

grown up learning that losing was evidence. You lose, so you practice more and figure out what the winner did that you didn't.

The injury ended the season without answering those questions. That was hard to fit into the rules I had learned. I had done enough to make the team, and I still didn't get the season I pictured. For a while, I acted like the injury meant making the team had never counted.

As I've gotten older, I've noticed how fast we reach for an explanation. We say the winner worked harder and the loser didn't want it enough. Sometimes that's right. Often we're reading the ending backward and inventing a story that makes the result look certain. After someone succeeds, a morning routine or a book on the shelf becomes the reason. We say that even when we don't know how much it mattered. We rarely look at the people who did the same things and still lost.

I did not understand any of that in eleventh grade. I just knew baseball was becoming something I used to do. Years later, I was teaching, coaching, building businesses, and raising sons. I was also losing things that cost a lot more than a baseball season. I kept coming back to one question: what does a loss actually prove? Sometimes it proves a lot, and sometimes it proves almost nothing.

That difference matters because of what we tend to do next. When people care about you, they want to make your pain useful fast. They say, "Everything happens for a reason," or "God has something better," or "Keep your head up." I get it. I have said those things too.

I am a Christian. I believe God can use things I would never have chosen. I also don't think my faith asks me to pretend I know why every painful thing happened. Some losses sent me in a new direction, and I can see that now because enough time has passed. But I

don't think every bad thing is fertilizer and we just keep digging until we find the flower. Sometimes the only honest sentence is, *I hate that this happened.* I'm more okay with that now.

What worries me more is when we skip understanding the loss and jump straight to fixing ourselves. If somebody beat you because they were better, getting better makes sense. If the loss came down to something close to random, that needs a different talk. If something was taken from you, hunting for your own failure can turn into punishment. If you've been winning the wrong game, working harder can take you further from the life you want. If you walked away because staying cost too much, calling yourself a quitter may get the whole thing wrong.

Those are different losses. I didn't know that when I was seventeen. I knew one thing: get back up. I'm grateful my father taught me that, and it carried me through hard seasons. Learning when to keep moving, and where to aim that effort, took me much longer.

KEEP READING

That was one kind of loss. There are five.

The rest of *The Pink Lemon* sorts them out:

1. Somebody beat you
2. The margin was almost random
3. Something was taken
4. You were playing the wrong game
5. You walked out

Each one asks for a different response.

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